

ADVANCING FIRST CLASS PRE-K IN ALABAMA

When the Director Leaves: Leadership Stability in First Class Pre-K

Turnover among site directors, principals, and administrative leaders, 2021–22 to 2025–26

JoonHo Lee and Alison Hooper ■ August 2026

Three briefs in this series have followed the teachers of First Class Pre-K; this one follows the leaders who supervise them. Using the same roster-linking approach, we track 1,264 site leaders—directors, principals, assistant principals, administrators, finance officers, and registrars—across 3,597 person-years from 2021–22 through 2025–26. We find that leadership is the program’s stable layer: about 11.9 percent of leaders leave the program’s rosters in a given year, compared with 17.7 percent of teachers in the most recent transition and 19.8 percent when all four teacher transitions are pooled. Although we describe those departures as turnover, more than a fifth of the time the leaders in question have not left the program at all but have changed roles within it.

Four findings organize the record, and the sections that follow take them up in turn:

- **Exit rates by role.** Holding a leadership position is associated with a lower annual rate of leaving the program: exit rates run 10.1–13.0 percent across the six leadership roles, below every teacher benchmark reported in this series (figure 1).

- **Internal role changes.** Of all non-staying outcomes, 21.7 percent are role changes inside the program, with directors becoming principals in 33 cases or registrars in 31, and administrators moving into the director role in 10.
- **Site-to-site moves.** Just 0.7 percent of leader person-years end in a move to another First Class site, which amounts to 26 moves in four years and 9 among directors, compared with 6.6 percent of teacher-years (figure 2).
- **Total change.** Combining exits, role changes, and moves, 17.6 percent of director-years end in some change, the most of any leadership role and a total that likely reflects the role mobility we observe around the director's position.

These are descriptive counts drawn from the roster census, and one scope caution applies throughout: we exclude three additional leadership roles, namely coaches, monitors, and regional directors, because their records cannot yet be linked with the same confidence.

Leadership Stability and Teacher Turnover

The teacher-turnover findings of briefs 6 and 7 raise a natural next question, which is whether the churn documented there is a whole-building phenomenon or a classroom one. Studies of K–12 schools have generally found leader departures to be associated with ripple effects, including higher teacher turnover after a principal change and improvement initiatives that stall between administrations. Because Alabama is weighing investments in retention policy, it matters whether the program's leadership layer belongs to the churn problem or to its solution, and the evidence we present below suggests that it belongs mostly to the latter.

This brief, the eleventh in the *Advancing First Class Pre-K in Alabama* series, extends the workforce analyses we reported in briefs 6–8 (Lee and Hooper 2026a, 2026b, 2026c).

BOX 1

Data and Methods

Data. First Class Pre-K staff rosters, 2021–22 through 2025–26, for six leadership roles: site director, principal, assistant principal, administrator, CFO/finance officer, and registrar. Records were linked across years into 1,264 individual leaders and 3,597 person-year observations with an observable next year. The leader linkage was checked against 832 institutional-record pairs (precision .989, recall 1.000, aided by institutional email addresses); this check was unavailable for teachers, so leader and teacher error rates are not directly comparable.

Outcomes. Each person-year ends one of four ways: staying in role; changing role within the program; moving to another First Class site in the same role; or leaving the program's rosters. As throughout the series, "leaving" means absence from the next year's rosters, not necessarily leaving the field.

Scope. Coaches, monitors, and regional directors are excluded (a 171-person manual review queue remains unprocessed). Role changes are reported without labeling them promotions or demotions. All results are descriptive; groups contain at least 178 person-years.

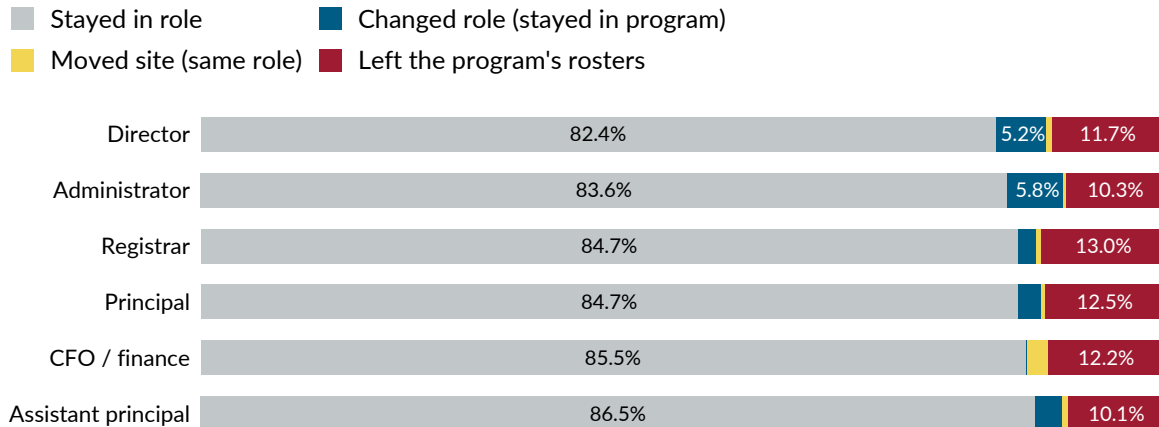
Exit Rates across the Six Leadership Roles

Figure 1 decomposes each role's person-years into the four outcomes. The gray blocks at the left, which represent leaders staying in role, run from 82.4 percent among directors to 86.5 percent among assistant principals, and program exits, shown in the crimson blocks at the right, range from 10.1 to 13.0 percent. Every one of those exit rates falls below the 17.7 percent teacher exit rate recorded for the latest transition, and all of them fall well below the rates for early-career teachers documented in brief 7, so occupying a leadership role in this program is associated with a materially lower annual probability of leaving the rosters.

FIGURE 1

Where Leader Person-Years End Up: Mostly in Place

Share of person-years by outcome, six leadership roles, pooled 2021–22 to 2025–26



Source: Authors' analysis of ADECE First Class Pre-K staff rosters, 2021–22 to 2025–26.

Notes: ADECE = Alabama Department of Early Childhood Education. Roles ordered by total change; person-years per role range from 178 (assistant principal) to 1,415 (director). Segments under 4 percent are not labeled.

Although this stability is encouraging for the program, it carries a caveat. Steady leadership gives quality initiatives such as coaching relationships, curriculum adoptions, and CLASS improvement cycles the multi-year administrations they require. Yet a stable layer may also be an aging one, and because these data record only whether a leader appears on the following year's rosters, they cannot anticipate retirements before they occur.

Role Changes and Site-to-Site Movement

The turnover we observe among leaders differs in kind from the turnover we observe among teachers, because about 22 of every hundred leadership changes are internal role changes in which the program keeps the person and only the title moves. Those flows concentrate around the director's position, with directors becoming principals in 33 cases over four years or registrars in 31, and administrators becoming directors in 10. We deliberately do not label these movements promotions or demotions, since titles map inconsistently across delivery settings and the rosters record the change rather than the reason for it.

The near-absence of site-to-site movement is the sharpest contrast we find with teachers (figure 2). Teachers change First Class sites at 6.6 percent a year, moving between schools while remaining in the program, whereas leaders essentially do not: we count 26 such moves in four years across all six roles, 9 of them by directors. Among leaders, leaving a site therefore usually means leaving the program's rosters altogether.

FIGURE 2

Teachers Move between Sites; Leaders Do Not

Share of person-years ending in a move to another First Class site, pooled 2021–22 to 2025–26



Source: Authors' analysis of ADECE First Class Pre-K staff rosters, 2021–22 to 2025–26.

Notes: Teacher rate from the companion teacher panel (moves between sites, same program); leader rate pools the six leadership roles.

That asymmetry suggests that the program has no internal labor market for site leadership. When a director leaves, the replacement is overwhelmingly hired from outside the program rather than transferred from another First Class site, which means that a director's departure is likely to present the program with a recruitment problem rather than a reassignment.

Discussion

Read alongside briefs 6 through 8, these results complete the workforce picture for the program, describing classrooms in which roughly a fifth of teachers leave each year and half a cohort is gone within three, operating under a leadership layer that holds remarkably still. Our results therefore suggest that

the leadership layer is an asset to protect rather than a problem to solve. With exits between 10 and 13 percent and most person-years ending in place, leaders are already achieving the kind of stability that retention policy hopes to produce among teachers, and if the churn this series has documented is concentrated in classrooms, that is where the marginal retention dollar may do the most good.

Moreover, because leaders almost never move between sites, succession rather than transfer appears to be the realistic planning instrument. A departing director cannot be backfilled from a sister site's bench, so a district or grantee anticipating a leadership vacancy would likely need to identify and prepare a successor inside the building, or to maintain a regional candidate pool. The internal role-change flows we observe, including the 10 administrators who moved into the director role, suggest that the inside-the-building path already operates, although at small scale.

Finally, the roles this analysis cannot yet observe are the ones most directly tied to classroom quality. Coaches, monitors, and regional directors—the three leadership roles excluded from our panel—remain outside the picture because their records await manual review, and processing the remaining queue would complete that picture at what appears to be modest cost.

Limitations

These analyses have several limitations. Exits are roster exits, which means that a leader who leaves may retire, may move into K–12 administration, or may continue elsewhere in early childhood, and these data cannot distinguish among those destinations. Role changes are similarly unlabeled, since a director-to-registrar change may represent a step down, a step toward retirement, or an organizational retitling, and we count only that the change occurred. Three roles are missing altogether, because coach, monitor, and regional director records await manual review and nothing reported here describes them. Stability is also not the same thing as quality, given that low turnover among leaders says nothing by itself about leadership effectiveness, only that whatever leadership the program has, it keeps.

References

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ABOUT THIS PROJECT

The Advancing First Class Pre-K in Alabama project examines First Class Pre-K funding, implementation, access, and comparisons with other state pre-K programs. Its goal is to offer recommendations for expanding First Class Pre-K while maintaining high levels of quality.

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